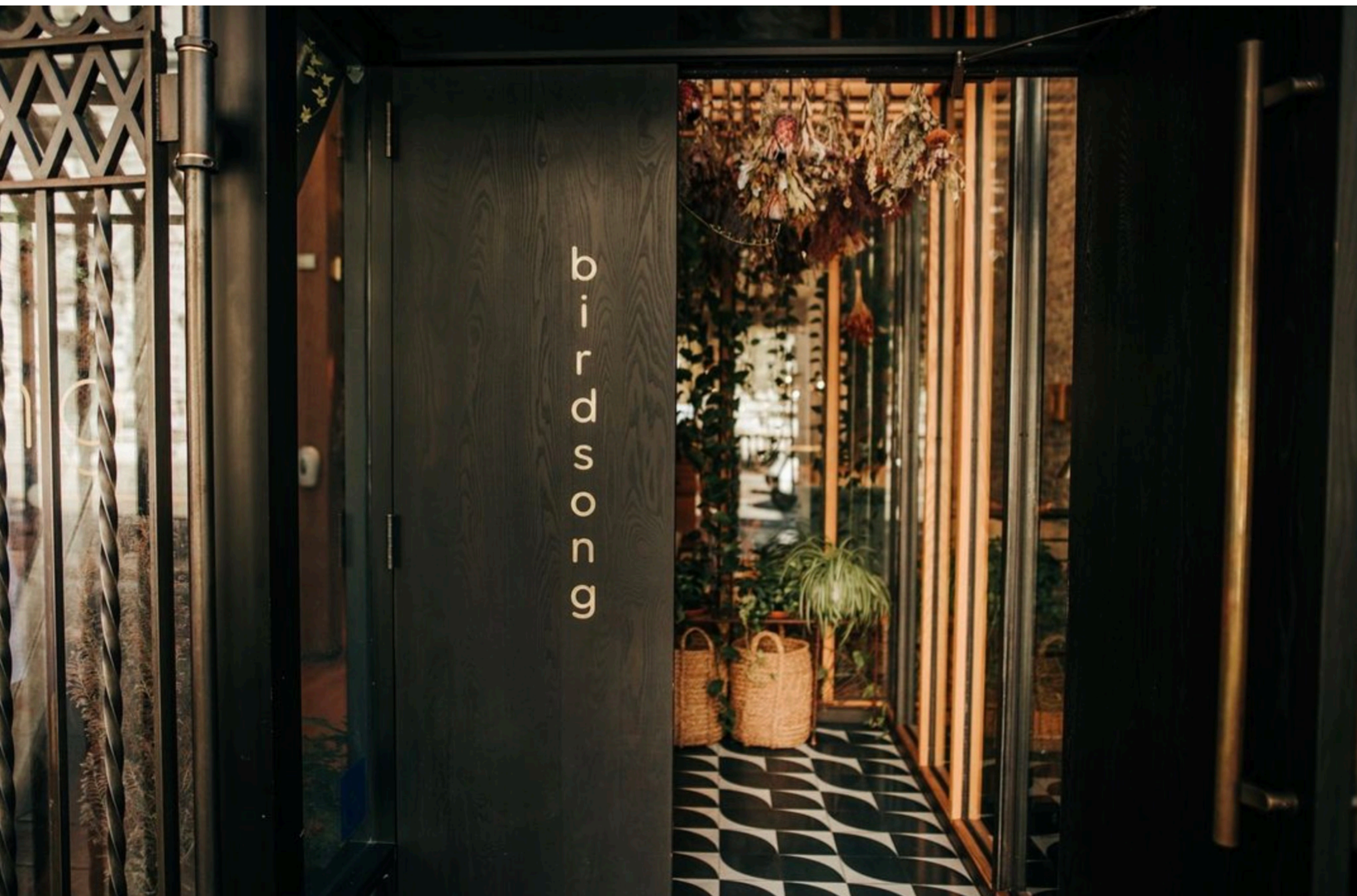




birdsong



DAVID SHAW
MAY 28TH, 2024



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HALIBUT

Halibut kombujime, lemon zest

Served with marinated seaweed salad and sea asparagus in a seaweed broth

DUNGENESS CRAB

Every part of local Dungeness crab

Smoked crab meat, crab brain fat, wakame, embered yam, house smoked piment d'Espelette

Grilled crab shell whipped cream

ABALONE

Abalone from Monterey, abalone liver chawanmushi, smoked and grilled sweetbreads, grilled thick cuts of abalone, steamed thinly sliced abalone

Picked chrysanthemum greens, daikon radish, kelp, and chives

All in a starchy abalone cooking broth dressed with a fat made from the remaining abalone innards

WHITE ASPARAGUS

White asparagus from Fresno cooked in its own juices then grilled

Fermented buttermilk curds, pork floss, cilantro blossoms

SEA URCHIN PUFF

Santa Barbara sea urchin on top of a pâte à choux made with fermented

shiitake and filled with savory butterscotch

QUAIL PART ONE

Two-week dry aged quail, lacquered with honey and smoked

Breast of the quail served in Peking duck style

Local lettuce, veggie trio pickles, fresh lime, garlic crisps, a bouquet of fresh herbs to be cut by scissors

XO sauce style condiment of the innards

QUAIL PART TWO

Two-week dry aged quail, lacquered with honey and smoked

Whole legs and wings enjoyed by hands

QUAIL PART THREE

Broth of the grilled quail bones, served with cut of fresh herb bouquet and lime squeeze

SQUAB PITHIVIER

Two-week dry aged squab

Center cut of the Pithivier of layers of shiitake, squab breast, and chicken mousse with pistachio

Served with liver sauce, glazed prune preserved with lemon zest and armagnac, and a heart wrapped with lardon

AGED LAMB LOIN

Thirty-day dry aged lamb loin from Anderson Valley served with lamb bone jus

Morel mushroom with hazelnut charcoal praline and almond skins

SEMIFREDDO

Pine pollen semifreddo with honey shortcake

Rhubarbs and strawberries

BIRTHDAY ICE CREAM

Ice cream made with a birthday cake

Served with condiments of marshmallow, whipped cream, preserved berries, brown sugar bites,

pecan pralines, sprinkles, and chocolate sauce

FAREWELL GIFT

Birdsong lamb jerky

Made with lamb from Anderson Valley ranch, marinated, then dried to preserve

Finished with fennel pollen and pine salt



Choosing a San Francisco restaurant is definitely not an easy task. Considering that we will only be staying for two nights, one being a Monday when most fine dining places are closed, we are left with just one dinner to decide on. San Francisco has big names scattered throughout, making it the only city in the States that can rival New York in terms of fine dining. Therefore, choosing just one among them can be quite challenging.

After much consideration, we settled on Birdsong. It promises an experience that I hope will be both fun and refreshingly unusual, fitting for celebrating my new age with a bold adventure. By peeking at their media posts, Birdsong seems to be something that I have never tried. There will definitely be a lot of dry-aging and smoking going on, but not necessarily a lot of fermentation which could be common for Scandinavian or

Asian cuisines. Birdsong provides a nostalgic, heritage-driven dining experience with a sophisticatedly pastoral touch. Birdsong nestles at a dangerous area, and upon arriving at their front door, we are somewhat shocked by the chaotic appearance of the street. It seems that homeless

Mexicans are squatting on the street, illegal vendors are trying to sell stale food, and strange people vaping marijuana behaving oddly. We manage to enter the restaurant as the clock strikes five. The dining hall is not necessarily expansive, yet it is spacious enough to be comfortable. The ceiling is high, and the decor employs a generous amount of wood, exhibiting a rustic, nostalgic temperament that somehow manages to act as a unifying thread throughout the dinner courses that are about to unfold.



First on the scene is halibut, meticulously cured under sheets of kombu and then sliced into thin pieces. Without a doubt, this dish carries a prominent Japanese gene. Though not named sashimi, the obvious adoption of the kombujime method provides rather irrefutable evidence. The addition of lemon zest and seaweed further substantiates this ubiquitous trend in today's culinary landscape. While it is no longer easy to impress with a sashimi dish, the chef at Birdsong manages to curate a marvelous broth that sends waves of excitement to our tasting buds. The broth is rich and concentrated in flavor, complementing the fish while maintaining a light texture that avoids overshadowing the delicacy of the sashimi.



Soon to follow the halibut is a crab dish that utilizes every part of the local Dungeness crab. Tourists who come to San Francisco will not want to miss the Fisherman's Wharf, and most may choose to dine at the pier. While the wharf is indeed a must-visit, the food there is not necessarily decent. One of the best yet niche ways to enjoy San Francisco's acclaimed Dungeness crab is here at Birdsong, where the natural rich flavor of the crab is complemented by the artistic dexterity of the chef. Presented in a square stone box, we find layers of components. First to catch our eye is a seemingly luscious, rich whipped cream made of grilled crab shell, which devours the smoked crab meat that is encapsulated together with crab brain fat. Digging through the captivating medley, we uncover a mesmerizing bed soil of embered yam, accentuated with wakame and house-smoked pigment d'Espelette.

With such a typical western style heavy bodied composition, it is not surprising that we fail to taste the hinted umami of the flesh which we would expect from a Japanese kegani dish. Yet the burst of flavors from each component creates a bomb that manages to excite each cell of our tongue. Similar to lobster bisque, the primary source of umami in this dish comes from the shell and the brain fat, while the flesh is mainly used to enhance texture rather than flavor.

The influence of the Japanese comes back in the next dish. Celebrating abalone from Monterey, the dish is presented in two layers. The bottom half is an abalone liver chawanmushi, and on top of the custard are smoked and grilled sweetbreads, cuts of abalone, picked chrysanthemum greens, daikon radish, kelp, and chives, all in a starchy abalone cooking broth dressed with fat made from the remaining abalone innards.

It is interesting for the restaurant to avoid using the term Chawanmushi. This Japanese title has been used by many other restaurants in an attempt to make their egg custard sound upscale and sophisticated. However, most immature executions fail to live up to expectations and only tarnish the name with pretentiousness. Maybe the chef here does not want this to happen, or perhaps he does not want his cuisine to deviate much from the so-called heritage cuisine. Either way, it is undeniable that the dish carries Japanese blood. The egg custard is in such a similar flavor style as chawanmushi, and the further use of abalone liver is just something the Japanese do traditionally. There is nothing bad to say about the silky texture of the custard, yet the abalone liver seems wasted, as this umami bomb is compromised and buried.

Interestingly, the top part reminds me of César Ramírez's soup creation at the original Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, which is similarly rich and fatty, featuring abalone and foie gras. The rich umami presented in various shades is undeniably pleasing, and the two contrasting methods of preparing abalone—grilled thick cuts and steamed thinly sliced pieces—are not only interesting but also functional in this soup, adding a pleasing variety of textures. The sweetbreads play a significant role here, enhancing the medley with a mesmerizing smoky aroma. The pickled chrysanthemum greens, standing out among all the vegetables, balance the rich unctuousness with a sharp yet refreshing acidity.

After indulging in two rich dishes with tons of fatty umami, we yearn for something lighter. With white asparagus in season, many restaurants are showcasing this delicate and sought-after vegetable. The Birdsong's take on white asparagus is rather unconventional. Here, the white asparagus from Fresno is cooked in its own juices then grilled, and served with fermented buttermilk curds, pork floss, and cilantro blossoms.





Following the somewhat disappointing asparagus dish, we have one of the most famous dishes of Birdsong arriving on the table: the sea urchin puff. This is a biteful dish at most, an amuse bouche served as an intermission, yet it explodes with an abundance of flavors beyond imagination. Before tasting, I judged it scornfully, suspecting it might be a mere variation of the ubiquitous uni toast seen around the world. However, it turns out to be a creation quite distinct from both our previous experiences and expectations. The dish features sea urchin sourced from Santa Barbara, resting on top of a *pâte à choux* made with fermented shiitake and filled with savory butterscotch. Unlike the ordinary sweet version, this *pâte à choux* is condensed and sophisticated. The shell is delicately crispy, and as I bite into it, an exciting lava core is exposed, showcasing a beautiful twist of shiitake and butterscotch that balances dark sweetness with savory umami. At first, it might seem like a conceivably overwhelming composition, but it should be regarded as a unity rather than just a highlight of the uni. Here, the natural sweet indulgence of the uni is perfectly balanced with the earthy, mellow umami of the puff pastry. This petit creation contrasts with the uni toast we had several times at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare and other locations, where the brioche base merely provides a backdrop for the uni to shine through.



If you wonder why the portion shrinks in the previous course, you will find the answer in the following act: the uni puff is simply a condensed course that bursts into a grandiose play showcasing three acts of the quail. The whole play unfolds in a staggering display, with an array of dishes presented before us. At the center is a rustic stoneware dish holding two pieces of the quail breast, surrounded by a trio of glassware for lettuce wraps, garlic chips, and a bouquet of fresh herbs and julienned vegetables. A pair of artisan scissors is placed beside the dish, and a duo of glass birds is carefully presented to display the unique condiments made from the quail innards, paying homage to the legendary XO sauce.



One of the most fascinating advantages of counter seating is that it offers a unique sense of involvement. Right at the start of our degustation journey, we see little birds hanging above the campfire, then being glazed with honey and smoked with wood and hay. Now, the birds are dismembered and presented in a pristine yet elegant setting. Additionally, this entire quail presentation is a do-it-yourself experience. For the first act, we will create our own wrap using the ingredients presented before us. To make the wrap, we have two varieties of local lettuce, pickled carrot, daikon, and spring onion cut into juliennes, fresh lime, garlic crisps, a spicy XO-style condiment made with gizzard and heart, and a bouquet of fresh herbs to be cut with the scissors. The waiter mentioned that this is a tribute to Peking Duck; however, as a Chinese person who has eaten plenty of Peking Duck, I can confidently say that this has absolutely nothing to do with Peking Duck. The presentation may be somewhat similar, but in terms of flavor, it is like chalk and cheese. In addition, I have to question the necessity of the two-week aging process. While the aging process gives the flesh a unique concentrated and rich flavor, it also sacrifices the juiciness. We find the breast quite dry, and even the succulent lettuce won't do any good. Moreover, the essential honey and smoky notes of the quail are somewhat encapsulated by the succulent greens and the so-called XO sauce. The whole essence gets trapped inside and fails to shine through.



Moving on to the second act, we are invited to enjoy the legs and wings with our hands. It is worth mentioning that the legs and wings are not presented separately but arrive with all the plates from the first act. We are instructed to enjoy the wrap first and then move on to the legs and wings. However, we are faced with the disappointing fact that both the legs and wings are completely cold at this point. Funny enough, as I mention this phenomenon to the manager, it takes him by surprise. He says they never heard about this problem before. Setting that aside, the legs and wings are far more enjoyable than the breast. All the dedicated dry-aging, glazing, and smoking finally pay off.

The final act of the quail course is a broth made from the grilled quail bones, served with a cut of fresh herb bouquet and lime. As the soup is presented, we find ourselves in an awkward position once again. The server informs us that we should reuse the bouquet we cut for the wrap, but since nobody told us beforehand that we would need to reuse it, we have almost used up the entire bouquet. Now we have nothing left to make the soup as aromatic as it is intended to be. This highlights the high risk of do-it-yourself games in fine dining, where the chef may lose control over the intended presentation and flavors. The poor design of this process is also to blame.



After a colossal ritual feast showcasing the rustic charm of heritage-style cuisine, the French delicacy comes promptly — a center cut from a petite yet luxurious Pithivier pastry. A complete squab Pithivier is made for every two guests, with only the most centered portion served. The rest of these simply become snacks for the staff — already a luxury compared to their regular meals. It is rather rare and interesting to see both quail and squab on one menu. However, the drastically different preparations prevent guests from becoming bored with the appearance of these similar birds.

In the Pithivier, a piece of shiitake mushroom is placed at the center, followed by the squab breast, which has been dry-aged for two weeks. This is all encapsulated in a layer of chicken pistachio mousse and then wrapped in puff pastry. To accompany the Pithivier, there are liver sauce, a glazed prune preserved with lemon zest and Armagnac, and a heart wrapped in lardons.

It is quite worrisome at first when I realize that we have to confront Pithivier again, especially after having a satisfying breakfast of a gorgeous and rather large Pithivier from Maison Nico, a local bakery established by another Michelin-starred chef. Maison Nico's version is without doubt refined and delicate, yet much less complex in terms of stuffing and presentation. It is by all means neither simple nor cheap — considering the generous portions of duck breast and foie gras—it feels more homestyle, cozy, and direct. Given this satisfying experience, I am concerned that Birdsong's version might not easily surpass it, especially since we are already quite full at this point, making it harder to impress us.

Luckily enough, I soon make a fool of myself. We are immediately blown away by the mesmerizing execution of the pithivier. Let's talk about the squab first. It is much more delicate than duck, and the natural gamey flavor plus the more concentrated smoky tone through the aging process makes it a total showstopper. The shiitake presents not only a rich source of umami but also a symbol of an oriental touch. The chicken mousse and pistachio are a magic touch. This layer almost turns the whole into a pâté en croûte, mild in flavor, velvety in texture, and rather refreshing, sublimating the whole into a harmonious equilibrium.





The Pithivier is so all-encompassing that it makes the three ‘amuse-bouches’ almost redundant. Don’t get me wrong; the side bites actually play an important role here. While the innards may not necessarily complement the Pithivier in terms of flavor, the presence of liver sauce and heart is significant because they complete the squab and demonstrate respect for the bird. If only the squab had a fattier liver, a similar approach to the Maison Nico version could be taken. Squabs, especially wild ones, have much healthier livers, and thus a sauce made from their liver would be a fitting homage. The heart is prepared in yakitori style, and the presence of its fiery, burning aroma adds an exciting contrast to the dish’s elegance, introducing a sense of unsettled impulsiveness that captures the spirit of birdsong. I particularly enjoyed the glazed prune preserved with lemon zest and Armagnac. It offers a unique, concentrated burst of flavor that is both addictive and complemented by a magical, gummy-like texture.



When the final main course arrives, I'm thrilled to see the fine cut of lamb loin from Anderson Valley, dry-aged for thirty days. However, I'm also a bit agitated. After two grandiose meat courses, will this lamb seem redundant? Might the trio of consecutive meat dishes feel monotonous without any seafood to break the pattern? It is a privilege to witness the process of the lamb being grilled and smoked in whole, then divided into small cuts in the open kitchen before us. On a stone plate, the lamb loin is dressed with a rich bone sauce and paired with some morel mushrooms stuffed with hazelnut charcoal praline and almond skin. The overall interpretation of the lamb is neither particularly innovative nor complex. Instead, it is a dish that showcases the essential umami of the lamb through a pristine, simple execution with finesse. The rustic and fiery cooking process imparts a unique woody smoky aroma to the meat and achieves a marvelously juicy and tender texture that is difficult to replicate on a household stovetop. Morel seems to be a popular pairing for meat and is usually stuffed with meat mousse. Here it is rather stuffed with nut praline and almond skin, which offers a sweet flavor and a delightful crunch. I particularly enjoy the almond skin, as it bestows the morel upon a flavor reminiscent of candied Chinese hickory nut. Finishing the last bite, I completely forget my concerns and I feel grateful to end the savory journey with such a fine cut of lamb. Though without any fish dishes, the playfulness and contrasts in the three meat courses make the experience memorable for us. Each of the three dishes is unique and significant.



The tasting menu then lands on a semifreddo dessert. Being the only dessert on the discovery menu, the semifreddo carries a lot of responsibility on its shoulders: it needs to be refreshing enough to cleanse the palate after three rich meat courses, while also being substantial and satisfying to provide a memorable coda.

Fortunately, the dessert concurs the challenges. Nestled in a deep black bowl is a hemisphere of pine pollen semifreddo accompanied by honey shortcake, with cubes of rhubarb and strawberry scattered around. How fascinating it is to have a dessert made with pine pollen! The flavor is mild, pleasantly mellow, and almost reminiscent of cheese or yeast. In semifreddo form, the pine pollen imparts a neutral, well-balanced sweetness that is both refreshing and soothing. The shortcake adds a rustic texture and an extra layer of sweetness, contributing to a satisfying finale. Rhubarb and strawberry introduce delightful fruity aromas and enhance the dish with their nuanced tartness and sweetness.

Just as I think the dinner finally concludes, the server presents me with a complementary birthday treat, an ice cream DIY set. Made with birthday cake, the ice cream tastes truly American, luckily it is not painfully sweet but rather richly mellow. The ice cream is served with condiments of marshmallow, whipped cream, preserved berries, brown sugar bites, pecan pralines, sprinkles, and chocolate sauce. Where should I start? I feel grateful to have so many choices yet the small portion of the ice cream means I am destined not to be able to taste all the combinations.

I am gratified to see that even a complimentary dessert course is designed with such creativity—perhaps this is the true essence of Birdsong. Indeed, as I mentioned earlier, DIY elements in fine dining carry some risk, but here I am willing to view it as a bold adventure in prioritizing the customer experience. For this, I hold the chefs in high regard. In this liberating atmosphere, we conclude a rich, enjoyable, and delightful meal. I am truly glad I chose to spend my birthday here.

